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Place Coverage

Nyanza Province, Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE SECLUSION PERIOD

Novices have special pastimes: catching and eating moles (which become forbidden food to a boy after he reaches full initiated status), shooting at birds with their sharp arrows, hitting each other with their blunt ones. The rule that they must not fight one another is not taken with the greatest seriousness except within the seclusion hut itself; if fighting occurs there, a special sacrifice has to be made.

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The novice is well fed. Not only is he pampered by his mother, who cooks her best for him and sends food whenever he chooses to ask for it: he can also ask his father to kill meat for him, and not be refused. The father may, for instance, be asked to slaughter a goat on a day when the novice wants to entertain some comrades. Then there is the special privilege of a novice to take food from the homesteads of neighbours if he thinks his parents have not sent him enough. Bananas, fowls, or even goats can be taken in this way. The father is obliged to recompense the neighbour if asked, but no reproach attaches to the novice or his parents as a result.

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As for special instruction during seclusion, the balance of my evidence is that Gusii novices do not receive any except what specifically refers to the rules of the novitiate. Most of my informants said more or less the same as Nyang'au: 'My sponsor only taught us how to behave like novices. Not to enter any homestead or hut; if we went somewhere, to remain outside and eat in the bush or at the granaries.' Francis said: 'My sponsor brought a basket full of branches and took them out one by one and asked me the names of the plants. Perhaps there were about twenty. Those I knew were perhaps fifteen. He did not punish me when I said "I don't know". These were the leaves to be burnt into ash for holding against the penis. He also taught me, "You don't call me by name now, but *sokoro yane* [grandfather]". Quite exceptional was the

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recollection of a Christian, now middle-aged, that during seclusion he had been taught the conventions of adult behaviour. 'I was taught, "Don't play with uncircumcised boys, don't keep company with uncircumcised girls. Don't go and take food from your mother's hut, but wait until you are called; don't climb into mother's rafters [food store]". These rules, which become obligatory after initiation, are of course familiar to every Gusii child long before; the spontaneous impulse to behave like a grown-up in such matters is a sign of the developing 'sense' (*obong'aini*) which is supposed to mark a child as fit for initiation.

'*Arousing Desire.*' During the first few days after *esubo*, at which time the wounds of circumcision have not thoroughly healed, parties of girls come to the seclusion huts 'to trouble the novices' (as the Gusii say) by what is called 'arousing desire' (*ogosonia*) Removing all their clothes, they dance around the novices in provocative attitudes and challenge them: 'You boy, you said you would become a young man [*omomura*] and have intercourse with girls;  23 now, are you ready? Here it is — what you wanted. Come Come and copulate!' (*Nchwo otete*, a direct utterance, employing a verb never voiced in decent speech). Using to the full their bent for pornographic language (well developed among young Gusii girls), they comment disparagingly on the genitals of the naked novices. The boys do their best to joke in reply.

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